Not The Best One

Short Stories.

<< Hello world >>

This is my first short story collection!

Never mind

Content #s

About the Author

Golden Introduction

Caramel Popcorn

1. Lottery
2. Special Jewellery
3. The Story of Anderson's Boots
4. Oliver's Empty Ride
5. Lanchum and its bright lights
6. Chef's Delicacy
7. The Gallery
8. December 18

Curious Burritos

1. Passenger and the Anthem
2. Two 'D's

Boba and his Tea

1. Poems
2. A day in the life of an Egg

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likes writing short stories.

Golden Introduction

Dear brave hearted reader, let me ask you a few questions!!

Is there a place on Earth where you can buy a cardboard flavored coffee?? Or play tennis with snails?? Or co-author a book with sloth that writes forever to complete a line??? Or a handbag made out of Jupiter rocks??? At least a handful of asteroids trying to speak English???

Meh… So weird, I know. But there is still one place where all of these are plausible.

And that place is...

Ur Chocolaty Brain.

Well, well, well, do you know what the most interesting thing that comes out from our minds is????

Stories.

We have been told many stories.

Ranging from, "Today I did this and that. My father slapped me, and I cried. My puppy fell into a fancy hole that smelled dirty, so I threw it into a pond, and now it knows how to swim! , I thought I was deaf but then alarm ringed loud by my ears and now I actually am deaf, Blah, blah, blah" to, "Once upon a time, there lived an average-sized man with a large tummy."

You have heard all kinds of it, and many times have even narrated them to others, no matter whether it was a fairy tale or was your own experience.

Stories evoke all kinds of emotions. But, most importantly, they entertain us![1] The stories here are written to swim through some moments of joy and bring out some short story excitement.

Written for,

Kids, Big kids, Old Kids and Kids who have kids in high school.

[1] Yeah, even sitting on the toilet seat with a smartphone can be entertaining

Caramel Popcorn

Lottery I

Colorful candies, fresh bread, packets of fried peanuts, rice, barley, milk, cheese, biscuits, chocolates, soaps, rugs, mugs, notebooks, pencils, slates and cold water stored in pots- and many more. What do you want?

Chacha's Provision Store has almost everything. It's the only shop still standing in the whole village. Located nearly half a mile from the village, it sits at the foot of the mountains, offering a view where the village appears like a tiny mouse with a foggy hat.

The shop itself blends into the landscape, a humble shed with wooden frames securely nailed at the corners. It stands beneath the generous shade of a sturdy, old banyan tree, whose dense green canopy keeps the shop cooler than the streets even on the hottest days. A prominently displayed name board— "Chacha's Provision Store"—sits on the roof, a familiar sight that every villager recognizes.

Shop owner Chacha wakes up at 4 AM and takes his scooter to a nearby town and buys from the market. He arrives within an hour

or two and opens the rear door of his shop mending and arranging the shelves. He tucks the new ones in place and pulls the old ones off the shelves—pop and poof. He then offers a Puja to the family deity, Lord Laxmishvara. A little rice bread and chutney for breakfast, and by 7, Chacha's Provision Store is open.

When the front shutter is opened, large coconut leaves drape over the shelves. Some items hang from wires at the front, while others are neatly arranged behind them. Fruits and sweet berries in bamboo woven baskets covered with fitting delicate lids that allow hands to juggle between baskets to give customers what they need- Fruits- this one- no not that variety- that little bright fellow there– one more kilo.

Though the structure may appear modest, it withstands rains and snowfall better than any lion's cave. Being the only provision store in the village, it enjoys a steady stream of customers every day.

By afternoon, his shop becomes bustling with activity. Chacha greets his customers warmly, engaging them in friendly conversations. Many visit just to chat with him, and end up leaving with something in hand. Even children can be seen eagerly heading to his shop after school, drawn by the familiar sight.

Chacha's care for his customers is evident in the small details, like the bamboo and coconut leaf seating area he's created beside his shop, offering a comfortable place for them to relax and chat.

He thinks of something new and different to make money whenever the income from his provision shop decreases. And one of the examples is his street food stall on winter nights.

In winters, as usual he runs his day business. But due to cold weather, people don't come out from their homes often. So, his day income goes down. To battle this, Chacha runs a Street Food stall at night. He keeps crispy snacks on the racks of the stall for sale.

As people arrive to buy his rare winter snacks, he lights the fire in a hollow cylinder in a dark spot and keeps a fry pan over the fire.

He pours in the fragrant oil and fries out potato slices, onion, chilly slices and other winter vegetables. He serves them hot and fresh, on the plates

Villagers wait in queues wearing their sweaters to taste the fine winter snacks.

Like so, his Shop ran with glory for somewhat 12-13 years.

Though Chacha used to make money from the business, he spent them to buy new provision items for the shop on a daily basis.

Due to lack of his money saving skills and old-fashioned business strategies, his shop suffered from severe loss when new supermarkets began near the village.

His shop now deserted. Dry leaves and dust were the only customers. Items in his shop went on decreasing.

Chacha though never saved money for his future, saved 230 rupees every year, for a lottery ticket… He always invested 230 rupees for buying a lottery ticket, hoping that the lottery, one or the other day, would settle his life completely.

And now, He only had a few regular customers and made only 1800 rupees this whole year! He was in a serious loss...

Almost 1700 rupees went into his daily needs. He was able to save only 100 rupees after all. He could not even buy a ticket! Lottery ticket was far from his reach. There was no chance for him to test his luck this year. Unsatisfied, he dropped 100 rupees into the savings box and went to sleep.

After a week, a small boy came to his shop. He asked for 4 chocolates and 3 bread loaves.

He paid 16 rupees. He then took the chocolates to his side and said "4!!", grabbed the bread and said "3 !!" and then gave a smile at Chacha and went back.

After 2 days, he came again. This time he asked for

4 chocolates, 3 bread loaves, 7 biscuits, 2 soaps and 9 candies. He paid 39 rupees and then grabbed the items to his side saying, "umm...4…3…7…2…9!!". He came to the shop for 3-4 days. Every time, he ordered 4 chocolates, 3 bread loaves, 7 biscuits, 2 soaps and 9 candies. He used to say, "4...3...7...2...9!!" every time.

One day, after buying all the items and grabbing the items to his side, he said

"Uhh…4…3…7…2…9!! ……. lottery!!!"

He saw Chacha's face and smiled for a second. And then he went back.

Chacha went and kept the money he took from the boy and dropped it into the savings box. To his surprise, the amount in the box was now exactly 230 rupees. "4…3…7…2…9" ran in his

brain again and again. He went and bought a lottery ticket. But his mind forced him to take the ticket which had numbers “43729”. He paid 230 rupees. It was all the money which he had with him at the time. He walked back to his home without any money.

He hoped for a win.

After 6 days, a village man came shouting...

“Chacha!! Chacha!! See here. You have won the lottery!! You now have 76 lakh rupees”.

Chacha was so happy. He went and claimed the prize amount. His life settled and he now had more than enough money to start a new shop.

He opened a new big mart. He named the mart- “Sri Ganesha Condiments”.

His venture started again. Everything went for him just like before; actually, it went even better than before. His shop gave him life once again.

One night, as he went to sleep, he pondered, "Who was that boy?? How did he tell me the right numbers??? And why did he pay me exactly the amount needed for the lottery ticket???"

Suddenly he exclaimed, "I know that boy!!!" His old memory strikes him.

It was a long time ago. Once Chacha was travelling in a train and when the train stopped at a station in between, he got out of the train and walked a little. The whole station was dark and only had a few candle lights. Chacha went to a nearby stall. A Man was roasting some good-looking peanuts in a pan kept on hot charcoal. The man's face was lit by the dim glow of charcoal. Chacha asked the man to pack some peanuts. By then, he saw a boy sitting in fear near the wall. He asked the boy... The boy started crying and said, "I got lost in the crowd and couldn't get into the train at the right time. I need to go to Haripuram, I don't have money". Chacha was about to go to Kanchi for an important negotiation with biscuit sellers. And Haripuram was 200 minutes away from the place Chacha wanted to go. But Chacha considered it right to take the boy to his parents.

On the train, they had a good talk. Chacha gave many flavourful festive snacks to the boy. Chacha told stories to keep the boy

entertained. Just think how a boy feels, when he is lost. But Chacha kept the boy calm and confident throughout the journey. Chacha cared for him like his own son. During this journey, Chacha even discussed about the lottery game and how huge the prize amount it had. Chacha even shared how important it was for him to win a lottery.

As Boy reached out to his parents, he came back to Chacha and said, "Chacha!! I will surely pay you for your help and care. I will surely pay!! I will!!!

Bye Chacha!!!"

As Chacha remembered this incident, he smiled!!!! It was that same boy who came to his shop to tell the lottery-numbers.

Special Jewellery |

"Hello my dear People!! Today is a special day for all!! I, the Owner of 'Gold&U' hereby announce that the gold biscuits in our shops will be on sale at just $2 per kg, for next 3 days!! This is a Golden Sale!! Come and make ur lives bright !!"

This announcement surrounds the city. Large LED screens in the city's busy streets show up this ad clip.

All stores get rushed up and not even a single gold biscuit remains in the stores. The Sale becomes a grand success and to celebrate this, the owner of Gold&U stores Mr. Hantim Aves arranges a get-together. He calls all his distributors and craftsmen.

Everyone was served with a special drink and a luxurious cake piece. The party ended within an hour and a half. At the closing

time, a poor person came asking for some food. Hantim himself rushed towards him and readily served him food. At last, Hantim gave him a golden ticket and assured him a new job.

Hantim indeed kept his promise. When the poor person came near his office the next day, Hantim welcomed him into his cabinet. After interviewing him, Hantim gave him an officer grade job with good salary.

Hantim was known for his kind activities. He was also very simple and down to earth.

From Businessman, he now had turned into a celebrity. People loved to buy jewelries from his stores.

One Day, a news reporter came and asked one of the buyers, "what makes gold Jewellery from this company so special??"

He answers, "It's the quality!!! So fine!! And the price. No others can give jewelries at such low prices."

Like this, Hantim was successful in winning the hearts of customers. He became one of the most successful people of that time.

But after some months, Hantim faced a problem. All jewelries in his stores went on missing as soon as they were sent into shops.

He fixed many CCTV cameras inside his shops and even took many security measures. But they were of no use. Jewelries went missing again and again.

And the interesting part was that after each missing, wood pieces were found inside the shops!!

Investigation began…

A fortnight after, Hantim was found on his office chair breathless. A death note sat on his table. It said, "Sorry, it was all my fault! I couldn't keep it up any more".

With no one to carry on the business, Gold&U
now closed completely.

People in the city were extremely depressed. Because buying jewelries from Gold&U had become a habit, just like bathing and eating food. Moreover, people had special respect towards Hantim Aves.

Like this, Calendar flips and Clock opens the door for 'NEW YEAR'. People who used to celebrate the fest with glory, were now little unhappy. But why?? Because they missed New Year Gold&U Sale.

Finally, after some long time, few Youths came forward asking justice for Hantim's death.

But City Court ruled out their request.

Gold&U Reborn

There were many people working at Hantim's company. Most of them were from this city. So, all these employees came forward to open the gold company again in order to start earning like before. Company came back to tracks. Now, the company exerted pressure on police to investigate Hantim's case.

This time, a professional Investigation officer was called for this case.

Investigation officer arrived. He hired a cab and asked the driver to go round the whole city.

He keenly looked everywhere and observed the city-workings. And all of a sudden, he asked the driver to stop. The place was very dusty and old. There were old buildings and ruined shopping complexes. He stepped out of the cab.

'Wood Toy House' was the word that got him down from cab.

He found only one person in that big old structure.

The person was old. He was carving toys out of wood.

He greeted, "Welcome young man!! What do u want?? Do u like to buy one of these toys??"

"No sir. I am here to know about this place."

"Do u really want to know about his place??? Oh no... go away. I don't know anything"

The Investigation Officer slapped the old man.

Finally old man agreed to tell him the secrets.

"U young man, I know, U are here looking for clues on Hantim's death case."

"U are absolutely right."

"I understand ur duty, young man...

But I can't tell U all the truth.

Because If I did so, it will be a big cheat that I am gonna make to U.

I will give U clues. U should do ur duty and solve this case."

"Sure." Replied the officer in bold serious voice.

"Clue number 1: When the person who killed Hantim comes in front of a mirror, he cries madly.

Second clue: The hollow cave under bed has 4 and 6 and 18 chambers.

And the 3rd clue, is within this puzzle, 'The gold Jewellery that burns in fire, is the final answer!!'

Good Luck Young Man."

Investigation officer who was already puzzled was now given an extra puzzle.

Readers, don't U think this Investigation Officer needs a name??

Let us call him Hilbert, for our convenience.

Hilbert went through old man's words. He walked in his lodge room the whole night, thinking about the clues.

Next Morning, he went to Hantim's office. He searched his cabinets and shelves. There was nothing special… except some expired chocolates.

He then headed towards Hantim's Home. Hantim had 3 houses. With a well-trained investigation team, he searched all the houses. All 3 houses were of no use, because they found nothing.

Meanwhile, he got to know that Hantim's wife was living in one of Hantim's farm house even now. He went there. The lady welcomed him with a pale smile.

Hilbert questioned, "When was the last time U saw Hantim??"

"It was day before his death, during mid-night. Hantim was looking very nervous that night. I don't know why he was so…"

"I see… Ok then, I will start investigating. Please stay outside till I finish my job"

And the lady went outside.

Hilbert and his team searched everywhere. But even this house seemed unpromising like those 3 useless houses which they saw before.

Hilbert was disappointed. He sat on a cushion. Just the moment he realized... it was a bed on which he was sitting on. He remembered a clue: hollow caves below the bed!

He asked his team to search the bed area thoroughly. After 28 minutes, they found a fancy tile below the bed. When it was

removed. A door opened. But they only heard the noise of opening of door, they didn't see the door. Hilbert saw here and there. There was a cupboard. He opened it. And as he took out the clothes, he saw that door. He went inside. It was indeed an underground place. But it didn't have chambers as old man said. He thought over the clue again. He felt, "What if, the number of chambers that old man told about was not actually the number of chambers, but were the secret passwords for opening the chambers??"

He uttered loudly, "4 6 18"

And then some bricks popped out from ground. Shining in golden lights, an elevator came up from the ground. It took them to a big cave. As they saw inside, their eyes opened big. It was full of Gold Jewelries. The Jewellery room was nearly as big as the house itself and was completely covered below.

Hilbert personally took some Jewellery pieces from the pile and kept into his pocket.

The investigation team successfully shifted all the Jewellery.

As Hilbert came to his hotel room, he started examining the jewelries. They were really wonderful. His mind once decided to go back to town with all these jewelries. But he came back to serious mood. He thought about the clues.

|| Clue 3: Gold Jewellery that burns in fire, answers the whole thing || this came into his mind.

He threw a Jewellery piece into fire.

It burnt and smoke came out of it!! And after burning, only ashes were left, no gold!!! His mind boggled at once. Next day, he tried burning other Jewellery pieces found in cave. They all burnt in same way. He then went to houses in the city and took gold jewelries which people had bought from Gold&U stores. Even these ornaments burnt the same way! He was puzzled completely.

"How can pure gold ornaments burn like this??? Gold never burns, it only melts!!! Why are ornaments turning into ash??"

With this puzzle mind, he went to Hantim's wife. He asked her about all these. She was innocent. She knew nothing.

Now, with despair Hilbert was coming out of the house, suddenly a thought cracked him and he asked, "O Madam, I have seen all the rooms here. But I didn't find not even a single mirror. I have never seen such a house!!"

"Oh that??!! Hantim didn't like mirrors. He threw them off whenever I brought new ones. I had seen him cry like a mad in front of mirror. After that incident I stopped keeping mirrors in house."

Smile bloomed in Hilbert's face. He solved the mystery by 60%.

"It was Hantim who cried like mad in front of a mirror. Then, Hantim was the one who killed Hantim. That means, Hantim's death was a suicide!!"

He went to that old man.

"Sir!! I cleared it. Hantim's death was a suicide. And indeed, I found gold ornaments that burns in fire.

All the gold jewelries sold by Hantim burnt in fire the same way!! But I could not find the answer behind those ornaments."

"Great Job Young Man!! Well, let me now, myself tell U the answers behind those ornaments.

Ornaments burnt in fire like dry wood with smoke, because they were indeed made of wood!!

Hantim made those ornaments out of wood, not gold.

Hantim colored wood ornaments with gold shine paint, which gave dry wood a shine of gold. He then dipped the ornaments into a hypnotizing potation. The potation's smell always hypnotized the people and made them believe that the ornaments in their hands were really gold.

When these were kept in fire, everything burnt off and even the potation burns off. That is why U see real burnt ash.

Hantim used this potion to run this whole fake gold business. When the potion with him was completely empty, he could not

make more fake ornaments and that is why he committed suicide."

Officer questioned, "But, one thing is not clear to me. How do U know all these and what Hantim is for U, in relation????"

"See here. See there. See this big shopping complex. This was once a big toy market. I was its owner. Thousands of people worked here. I invented a potion to spray over the shop entrances, to attract customers to all shops in this complex. And that Hantim stole my potion container and ran from here. He opened his gold business. When purchasing real gold became hard for him, he sprayed the potion over fake ornaments and sold them.

And…U asked about my relation with Hantim, right??

He was my son…..."

The Story of Anderson |

It's a big city. The streets are very competitive. It is very hard to find a job here. People here are somewhat mad. Money is the most respected thing. In this city, there is a beggar. His name is 'Anderson' and he has no blessing of speech. He does Weaving works and type writing. But most of the time, he is a beggar. He lives in a tent which he has made using plastic sheets.

The city corporation has placed garbage bins in every gap between the buildings. His tent is behind one of those garbage bins placed between high rise buildings.

The man comes to his regular begging place in the late morning. You can find him sitting in his place, if you pass by the road after 8AM.

Sometimes, he is even found busy on his typewriter. The city corporation officer gives him typing work often. When he has no

work to do, he starts begging. And the surprising element is, people show pity on him!! No other beggar receives such a kind of pity in this city. He earns some money, but he is never found spending his money. He always eats stale bread and toast. In the evening, when his begging business slackens, he does some weaving work. He makes some patterns on cloth and keeps them for sale.

Most of his patterns are weird and uninteresting. He will leave the place when the number of people in the streets goes down.

He walks, walks, walks and finally vanishes. Nobody has seen his house or him entering his house.

Next day, the city wakes up again. All businesses start back. As usual, the corporation officer came to ask the beggar to type some documents. But the beggar was not there! Officer was in frustration already and didn't have much time. He shortly enquired nearby stores and they informed that the beggar hadn't come today.

The officer went back in disguise. The blowing wind waited for the beggar till evenings, and then went back. The stars stared at the place where he used to sit, but he didn't come even now. The moon lit the streets to find him, but he was not there.

Next day, he was found dead in the middle of the road. Blood flowed from his head and had painted the road in red color. It was even before morning. By 6 AM, people gathered. The corporation officer, who used to employ him, even came there, after hearing the news. Police came to the place and sent the body for post-mortem. The place was marked in white paint and barricades taped the place around. The road was blocked and alternative roads were directed in sign boards. The post-mortem reported as such,

"Medical reports confirm that he died from severe head injury, followed by massive loss of blood. It is suspected that he fell from a high building. No marks of

What happened? Blank pages!!

Blame the Satan!!

fingerprints or other body traces. Death time: appr. 4:29 AM."
Beggar's Death case was ribboned as a Suicide.

After Beggar's Death, many crimes and robberies got reported consistently one after another. All these crimes came to light from nowhere in no time. Major of them was the death of Famous Business Icon Jimmy Parker.
Now the investigation team hurriedly jumped into work. The case went well and got updates soon. The evidence was not found though.

Amidst these, city corporation officer who had pity over that beggar, went to the police station and asked them to reopen the beggar's case.
The police inspector told him, "Whose case?? Beggar?? Oh no. I can't help you to reopen the case. There are already a lot of serious cases here. We have a lot of pressure to investigate the death of that rich man Jimmy Parker, and many other robberies! Go away!"

"Sir, believe me, that beggar looked very innocent and determined. He was not a man who would commit suicide. And moreover, all the major robbery and crime cases started coming after the death

of that poor guy!! Maybe that poor man knew something that got him killed!!" suspected the corporation officer.

"Come tomorrow. I can't do anything today" And the officer went back. The next day when he came to report, he was pushed out of the station. After some days, a police constable voluntarily came to visit corporation officer at his home. He said, "That day, I saw you in the station explaining the case to the Inspector. After hearing your words, I too feel that the case needs to be opened. I can help you." "Thank U."

"Ok, I will come tomorrow. I myself will investigate this case personally. That inspector will never take on the case. He is narrow-minded"

And the next day, he did come. Corporation officer now took a leave from work and accompanied the police constable.

Police constable asked him, "So first I would like to see his house. Show me the house".

The officer replied, "I have never seen his house. I just know that he lives in a tent behind one of the garbage bins."

They both went and checked each and every garbage bin in the street. Behind one of them, they found a plastic sheet covering the back of the bin. They pulled it off. There was a small tent covered

in a half-torn blanket. They saw two tent poles and some items that the beggar used. The tent was big enough for 2 members to sit at a time. Police checked every item. And he found a small piece of paper inside a coffee container. These words were
written on it- "Tomorrow 4:30 AM"

"The time written on this is very close to that time when the beggar died, right??" asked the police. "Yes," replied the officer. And then they continued the search for hours throughout the place. But all they found was trash and a half-burnt cigarette, which the police constable himself had thrown, an hour ago.

"It looks like a perfect suicide, nothing more than that." said the police. "Please check once more, sir," said the officer.
"No!! It's a normal suicide!! I shouldn't have wasted the time by believing your words!!" yelled the police and hardly stamped his foot on the ground. A metal sound was heard. Both the faces lit up. They brushed the ground and then dug out some soil. They found a small metal closing. Police opened it. He lit up a matchstick. It was a drain hole. The drain was half filled in drainage wastes and standing water. Constable said, "No, it is just a closed drain hole."
"But why don't we go and search once??" asked the officer.

Constable looked at him in an angry disgusting view.

"I won't go in!! You can go, if you wish to take a bath in this ugly drain water" rudely spoke the Constable.

But then, he thought over it again and again, and after a minute said, "Ok, I am ready to risk my life in this ugly garbage. Come on"

Both went inside covering half their faces with masks and with covered legs and hands. Pocket light torches lighted their knowledge about the drain room.

It was indeed uglier than they thought.

"How long before was this drain cleaned, my dear corporation officer???"

"I don't know. But we will surely start cleaning this drain within 5 years, after someone complains about it."

"Dammit. I should have complained 5 years ago then"

Constable's hand searched for things in drain wastes. He found many ugly things. "Yuck!!" said Constable.

"Don't worry sir; I will buy you a tasty Mc Burger tomorrow."

Constable became angry again and threw his torch. Torch fell into the waste and stood there. The torch, before it went completely into the drain, lighted the upper left corner of one of the sidewalls of the drain room, and there was a rusted mesh over there. Constable took a torch from the officer. The mesh looked

like a window. They somehow broke it. There was a narrow tunnel… They went through. At the end of the tunnel, a room was what existed there. It seemed like a store room. There was a diary book, some candles, some inked papers, torn pieces of photos, some tiny boxes with ash like material in it and a weird pattern cloth piece. They took them all and came out. The police constable asked the corporation officer to come to his home the next day. At home, they went through all the items.

The ash boxes were sent to the lab to check its contents. The diary was written in very rubbish hand-writing and hence he called a language professional. A special officer came to read the things written on that weird pattern cloth.

As the language professional narrated the writings, both were surprised. The ash boxes were not actually ash, but it was life-killing poisonous powder. The weird pattern cloth was actually a Map to Jimmy Parker's bedroom. When the torn photo papers were joined, the photo was found to be that of Jimmy Parker and his family.

The diary had the signature of Beggar at the bottom!! This confirmed Beggar's authority over the diary.

And Beggar's diary spoke these words…

"Today is April 28 1986, A disaster.

Who am I?? Jimmy Parker!! The great business man who turned the whole entrepreneur field into heaven!! But one day finally came in my life that ruined my life forever.

Today, after my business hours, when I came back home, my little daughter demanded to go for a walk on the streets. We went happily. On the way, we met a beggar. He asked for money. I gave 20 dollars. He looked at me twice. Though $20 made his face bright for seconds, his face expression changed and I saw a scary plan running in his mind. Actually, he looked somewhat like me in physique and face. He was similar to me. Maybe that is why his facial expression changed. He understood that I was rich business man Jimmy Parker and hence he followed me secretly.

I held my daughter's hand and wife's hand on the other side and tried moving out quickly. As it was night, the surroundings were deserted. Beggar finally came in front of me. He sprayed something on me. I feel it was some kind of anesthetic powder. I fell down.

As my wife and daughter shouted, his hands went near his shoe. A syringe came out. It went right into my wife and then into my little daughter. He injected it quickly. I don't know what he injected, but when it went into my wife and daughter, both started suffocating and died with blood coming out of their noses.

I lost my wife and little daughter forever there itself. As I gained hold over myself, he gave a hard hit to my throat. From then, I lost my ability to speak. He threw me into the garbage. His team shifted my lifeless wife and daughter without any clue.

After days, I got to know that the beggar changed his look completely with a surgery and has now entered into my company as Jimmy Parker!! He and his wife are now living luxuriously at my home. And I, The Great Jimmy Parker, am sitting near the garbage begging, with pseudo-name 'Anderson'…."

And the lines written before his death-day were as follows,
"Today September 12th, I am gonna complete my life's aim. I will kill that guy who sent my loved ones away from me. Today, I have sprayed life killing ashes on that fake Jimmy without his notice. He will die within 2-3 days for sure. No one can detect the poison in his body. My true friends in Africa will sell all the company assets and use the money for the upliftment of the poor in that region. As everything is on perfect track, and as I don't have anything to live for, I will leave my life. I will fall from that same building which had given me a place to sit below, for these many days. I am coming!! My wife and little daughter, I am coming!!!"

After hearing, both went speechless. They were astonished by the real truth behind all the deaths and robberies. It was a single man behind all the deaths indeed. But the deaths were worthy.
Police officer went and checked accusations filed over Jimmy Parker. There were cases filed on Jimmy only after 1986. And police officer also found that the other robbery cases reported were all related to the people who were supporting fake Jimmy Parker.
The police officer concluded that it was right to leave this case off as things had happened the way it should have happened...

After some years, when Corporation officer went to the police station to meet that police constable, the inspector asked him, "Shall I reopen that beggar's death case?? I have fewer cases now!!"

"There is no need to open that again. It's alright" replied the officer and gave a smile to the Police Constable.

The Constable looked back at the corporation
officer and smiled with satisfaction…

Oliver's Empty Ride |

Oliver is back on his horse cart. Sits comfortably leaning his back to the soft cushion of the seat. He opens his Coat's sleeve buttons and takes off the coat. Throwing the coat reluctantly makes it sit at the base of the cart. The horse stamps tick like the clocks and Oliver dials his organizer.

"Hello!! It's me sir. I called you to ask about the time schedule for my next drama. And did you think of my request?? Incrementing my salary?? Sir, Sir????"

And the phone call cuts off. All Oliver could hear now was what he was talking, with no response from the other side. The organizer just cut off the call as soon as he heard Oliver bringing his payment issue. Oliver bitted his lips in disappointment and asked the coachman to move faster. Oliver looked outside with a

humble face. The pace with which everything moved backwards increased and confirmed the sign of horse cart moving faster.

Coachman slowed the horses suddenly. Oliver wasn't expecting this. Coachman asked Oliver to get down the cart and spoke out, "This is all the way I can take you to, for the money you gave me. U can go now"

Oliver tried convincing him, "But at least leave me home, I will pay, I will Pay after I get my payment.
It's already dark, and it's not even town, we are in the middle of hilly outskirts. Don't leave me like this"

Coachman moved forward without hearing a single word from him.

Oliver looked around again. It was completely dark and moreover; the place was looking spooky and scary under the Full Moon's backdrop. He didn't know the route to his town. He was very far from the urban sky rise buildings. Trees, bushes and some grasses were all he could see around. He decided just to spend time there, till the sun rises. He spread his coat on the muddy road and leaned down. Within a moment before he takes a breath from the fresh air, his heart beats faster, dictating his fearful inner thought "What if some vehicle came in this route overnight and went over my body??" He shifted his coat from the middle of the road to the

edge. His eyes opened quickly, "What if ghosts passing nearby caught me here in the sides??"

He slowly shifted himself into and into. For now, he was in a grassy area, and actually in the middle of the scariest dense forest. Not able to understand where to go, he slept confidently over the grass.

Though he made up his mind to lie down, insects did not allow him to do so. Ants came in swarms and began biting. Flies came buzzing. Who had asked for a body massage and a violin concert in the middle of the forest?? But they did their sacred duty to entertain their rare guest.

Oliver's legs stood up themselves, unable to tolerate the nice bites of ants. His hands rushed to scratch the regions where ambitious ants make their teeth marks. He looked here and there, and found an old sturdy tree with fat and wide branches. He climbed it up, made quite arrangements using leaves and dry grasses and slept over there.

Morning, he woke up with glowing eyes! Jumped down from the branches and dragged his coat from above. Something fell off. Just a few seconds later, he discovered that it was his mobile phone. "Oh Man! I could have dialed my friends using this! I

hopelessly slept here all night." And whispering this to himself, he lifted up the phone. Phone's display had shattered. Better had he not kept his phone in his pants pocket... His bum had crushed the mobile's face. The sole hope that had lit his face all these minutes, suddenly fused out. Oliver threw the bent phone and just went on walking forward… Yea he continued, afternoon, then evenings, then again damn dark night. This night, his new friends started Pop music. The humming insects, screaming birds, howling wolves. All sounds were in such a damn perfect rhythm that; it resembled a music concert. But not entertaining… for sure.

Oliver was the only one who was quiet in this concert. Finally, Oliver sang his opening song.

"Mummmmmy!!!!!!!!"

and all his friends stopped their music for a second to hear his song and then again continued with their POP. Maybe they didn't find Oliver's song good enough…

Oliver's face shone in moonlight and reflected a blissful bright face-cut, but his inner thoughts contained a deep fear that questioned his future tirelessly. His heart never stopped beating more than normal. With uncertainty of the future, Oliver's eyes filled with water. He briskly saw in every direction; his hope was

all done. It was 200% sure for him that he would stay here forever. Every path looked the same and Oliver, who never had the experience inside a bushy dense wood, now suffered from map lessness. In following days, Things were all the same for Oliver except they decreased his hope of getting out.

He transformed into a Semi-Urban Tarzan and passed time singing chorus with his new friends… Oliver completed 1 successful year and celebrated it by sitting on the crashed mobile phone, which his bum had crushed a year ago.

After months, another human being came inside the forest! But he was not deviated for sure. He was a National Geographic Channel adventure hiker. He had come to explore this forest. He was expecting only animals in this forest, but there stood even a strange animal that resembled a human being.

Hiker went forward, saying the creature as 'human faced-chimpanzee'. As he approached near, it was clear to him that it was a real human. Oliver smiled showing 32 teeth-set and held hiker's hand. Hiker managed to stand with his camera and mic, even though Oliver's hand had approached him at taxi speed. He decided it right to interview him. Oliver told his whole story. He begged to take him out.

Hiker didn't want to show people that Oliver was a person who by mistake came to this forest, instead he wanted to show Oliver as a Tarzan living in the Jungle for decades, because this would make the Hiker popular for discovering a new Tarzan! So, he recorded the video showing Oliver as a Tarzan staying in the forest. His idea was to portray that Oliver was an ancient Tarzan species who still lives in the forest! Oliver asked him, "Oh I wanna go outside, take me out!"

Hiker spoke looking at the camera lens, "Oh, no, no, we don't wish to miss a true Tarzan like U! We are proud of you sir! The country should be proud of this creature living here!! Ladies and gentlemen, I feel it is right to leave this secret life of Tarzans here itself. Natural beauty should not be destroyed!!!! Hip-Hip-Hurray!" and he turned back trying for a clever escape…

But Oliver climbed over his back and bitted Hiker's ears. Then pulled the hairs. Gave a donkey kick and painted Hiker's lips with extra lipstick red.

This entertaining clip was recorded on the hiker's camera… And so, after the hiker managed to escape out from the forest, Police cops came to the forest!! Cops screamed, "It's time to take you with us!!!" "Heh, heh, you are so kind!! Policemen are Gods. Long live policemen!!!!!" cried Oliver with a heavy parabolic mouth.

Oliver came and sat inside the Police van. He was so happy that at least Cops came to take him out of the forest...

He now got excited to go out to start performing dramas on stages and earn money like before!

Gradually the police van surpassed the bushes and
came out of the forest. But it didn't stop … It went, went and went… It was only a day after which he understood that he was shifted to a zoo...

Lanchum and its bright lights|

"Come on my child!" says grandpa to his granddaughter and lifts the 5-year-old into the big bamboo basket of a hot air balloon. A pale tall boy lights up the fire at the base of the balloon hold. The giant-sized balloon rises up. Boy jumps quickly into the base and plugs out the wooden anchor. "Where are we going, Popu??" asked the little girl to her granddad. Grandpa held his finger over his lips and gestured to her that it was a secret.

It was night. The surroundings were so dark that one couldn't see the other's face. Little girl managed to see her granddad's face continuously from the bright glow of fire that was above their heads. The hot air balloon was going above the sea which separated two grassy mountain ranges. Below one of the ranges, there was a town. The town to the left of the sea shore. Town Boston.

And below another mountain range, there was a great place, Lanchum. Even this was a town, a well built and prosperous town. It was the home of merchants, circus workers and theatre artists. The residents of the town stayed in Lanchum only for 6 months in a year. The other 6 months, all the residents lived somewhere else. This was a secret. Residents left all their things, jewelries at their homes and their home doors completely open during this period.

Before leaving the town, residents celebrated a fest. Fest of trick games.

Granddad Peter was taking his granddaughter to show this fest. Hot air Balloon came midway across the route, while they both heard a shout.

"Come back you both!!! Hey you boy, bring the hot air balloon back to the shore right now." Boy turned to Peter. Peter nodded his head in disguise. Boy turned the fan and adjusted the flame. The balloon landed at the same shore from which it started its journey. A sturdy looking man came running with a woman. Granddad didn't see the faces in front of him. But he was sure that the person yelling at him was his son.

"Dad, I warned you not to take my daughter with you to that weird town fest. And it is dark, what if ...what if something had happened to my little cutie pie?!"

His son took the little girl on shoulders and returned back without talking a single word with his father.

Grandpa Peter asked the boy to take him to the other side of the sea. Hot air balloon rose up in the air. After a curious wait, finally he reached the opposite shore. He handed the boy 2 dollars and headed front. He pulled out his lamp and started to climb the mountain, behind which was the glorious town.

As he climbed the top of the mountain, he checked his pockets. He had kept some glucose candies. But he didn't find them anywhere in his pockets. He had left them inside the hot air balloon. He looked back. Balloon was reaching the other side. Balloon glowed yellow with the man standing inside looking like a teddy bear. The fire had lit a bright reflection over the waves of the sea as it went.

Peter slipped on the grasses staring at the balloon and fell down to the other side of the mountain. Slipping had made his way easier. He now was at the entrance of the glorious town. But old man

Peter was injured. As he moaned a little, a person with black beard came to help. He wrapped cloth over the injuries.

He seriously asked Peter, "Why did you come here?? Don't you know that non-residents are not allowed to the fest??"

"I do. But ever since my childhood I wanted to see this fest and the town's culture. I was not allowed to enter this city all these days. It is my dream. Help me"

"Ok, but for an agreement. You are going to help me when I ask you," said he.

Agreed Mr. Peter with no other choices in front of him.

Both walked into the main street of the town. The fest was so grand. There were many games to play: Popping the balloons, jumbling the puzzle, lottery, magic show, jumbo circus, astrologer's outlet and many more. Peter went to play the lottery at first. Dropped a quarter dollar coin into the opening and pressed his choice of numbers onto the machine. Peter waited for a minute with his lips widened and a pale smile. But then, the man who accompanied him told him that the lottery would be announced at the end of the fest.

Peter lifted his nose up and gave an unsatisfied look with his tightened forehead. He came forward to try the next game in urge.

"Haven't you ever seen a fest??" asked the bearded man, "You look so excited as if you are seeing it for the first time" added he.

Old man's face showed some grief from inside which though looked pale under his excitement. He said, "Is there a place other than Lanchum where such fests take place??? I thought you knew this better than me..."

"Yea Old man! you are right. Such fests are only in Lanchum. Haha..."

Peter nodded in disguise. He knew that the man was making fun of him.

The next stop was at the power tomb. Old man took the rubbery hammer and hit it hard at the base of the tomb. The metal ball surpassed the chart reading and touched the bell at the top. The sound waved through. The merchant owning this game stall woke up from deep sleep. He was resting on his chair peacefully. Even the sleep snored when it saw his face, such a sleep-sloth he was. Merchant rubbed his ears and stretched his arms.

"How old are you??" asked Peter to him. He said, "45"

"I am 78. Now give me the prize before you fall asleep once again"

Merchant gave him a soap and smiled heavily.

The smile was so sarcastic that it stopped Peter from questioning more.

As they walked, Peter handed the soap to the bearded man saying, "It better suits you." Bearded man took off his hat at once. The hat had many pockets which had 4 soaps pushed into them. Old man understood.

They walked forward looking here and there. Peter stopped at a bubble gum stall. He purchased some rare bubble gums for his granddaughter. He was excited to surprise her with these gums, on his return to the town.

By then, a lady briskly came in their way intently. She hurriedly stopped them by holding their legs and asking them to visit her astrology stall. Old man stood blank for a moment. Lady's rush to hold his leg had frightened him of his loose pants being pulled down all in sudden.

Old man Peter touched his legs twice only to confirm that his pants were in place.

Both sat on the chairs placed inside the astrology stall. The lady came with her crystal ball and some cards. "O Lady! Tell me about my future. Quick" added Bearded Man.

"Your future is going to change from now, Walton," said she.

"You know my name?? Wooo... well how's my fate going to change??" asked he curiously.

"You will know that in an hour," said she glancing crossly at the old man.

"You may go now," said the lady.

"O madam! Me?? Won't you tell me about my future??" anxiously questioned Peter. "It will be better not to tell," smiled she.
"Peter, leave this! Enjoy man..." spoke Walton, "I will be back soon, just a minute" and went he.

Peter just sat down waiting for Walton to return back.

In a while, a thing caught his eyes all of a sudden. A bottle was going up in the sky and fell down in the glaze... It went up and fell down again and again.

He walked towards it looking at it all the way...

There was a big crowd. A person stood in the middle and threw a glass bottle into the air again and again. Peter asked people about the game, nobody answered. They were in their own seriousness.

He moved around. Found a person looking smilingly, at the bottle. Asked him.

He answers, "Looks like you are not from this town... Came to enjoy?? Heh?? Let it be...

This game is kinda different... The bottle decides the place to which each resident should go for the next 6 months. See that bottle; it has a holy chit in it. The chit has the name of the town a resident need to go to. Headman decides the place name for every resident and keeps it inside the bottle. Headman then calls the resident and throws the bottle up. As the bottle thrown up crashes the ground, that resident is revealed to the name of the place he/she needs to go. They need to work in that place for the coming 6 months and all they gain will be added to their home's locker and they will be allowed to live in this town after 6 months if they earn well...Chit decides the fate of the person. The chit can even have other things written in it!! This bottleneck game has a vast history and religious descent… U won't know! Go bybye..." shifted his sight at the bottle again.

Walton returned. "What's going on??"

"Nothing. Just a casual talk" replied Peter.

And both continued on their walk. "Well, when's your turn, Walton??" enquired Peter.

"Uh... Headman will shout my name when it's my turn... There're still 3000 bottles to go... let's enjoy!" Walton took the old man to sweet shops. Both savored some great sugary confectionery. Old man's excitement was so high that he pointed towards Pastries even after eating so many sweets. He asked for one more, even before he swallowed one. His mouth was full and about to burst.

Old man now took out his questions, which he had since childhood.

"I have heard that people here leave their home doors open with all the precious items inside when they go for a 6 month out-life... is it true?? And why so??"

"It's the ritual Mr. Peter. Our Text says that if something goes missing from their homes after the 6 month out-trip, then it means that the thing lost didn't really belong to them from fate...

Many residents have lost things since decades, but it doesn't matter... People here believe in Work"

"So, what do you do?? Your Job??"

"It's a secret, old man…"

"How many secrets does this place hold?? I can't bear this...," said the old man.

"Walton Ubers!! Walton Ubers!! Walton Ubers...," shouted the Headman.

As Walton heard his name called by, his face turned deeply pale... His eyes shrunk in size and cheeks stretched plain. His eyeballs reflected his inner thoughts. The summer sun had turned into a cold iceberg for him. His blood flooded into his inner pipes at once.

Old man asked, "What's the matter?? Hello??

Headman called your name...won't you go??" He nodded and tried moving his legs forward. His legs shook and refused to move. Old man pushed him. He resisted. He looked at the old man... Looked him from top to bottom again. And again.
His lips refused, but he spoke, "Old man, it's your time to help me... you had promised..."

"OK tell me, I will help you"

"You go to the Headman and ask him that, you would play the bottle game instead of me...

I will stand beside you. You play. Instead of me. Convince the Headman that you will stand by the game and that you will play my turn in the game...

Old man!?"

"Ok... I will!!! Just a game right... I am also curious to see the name of the place on that chit. Come on, let's go. I am ready to play at your turn" smiled the old man.

He shouted at the Headman and announced on the street that he would play Walton's turn as per his request.

Headman asked him thrice whether he was sure to play at his turn...

Old man nodded smilingly. The crowd looked at him. Headman contained his feelings and sighed... The bottle went up. Old man's head turned up in smile. The bottle turned, glazed and fell to the ground. It had twisted 2 lives unknowingly. As the bottle broke, the strong air cleared the chit to the audience.

It contained the words – 'Hang him to the mount'

People headed towards the old man, to do the thing printed on the holy chit.....

The Gallery I

"The only cigarette left"- whispered Markov. I wonder why he said so when he had one more pack of cigars in his pants pocket.

"You are not supposed to bite nails," I said. They were no different from the bark of a 100-year-old banyan.

"The street is busy, yet those birds are sitting on poles chirping loudly. Then why can't I relax my anxiety by biting my nails? " He replied.

He always has a counter.

"Jerry, I am in a hurry," he spoke to me, showing his damaged fancy lighter.

It translated to me as - I need a new stylish cigar lighter to light my remaining cigarettes. You know, I can't buy 'em alone, come with me."

Now I know why he said "the only cigarette left".

And I sat on his cool looking blue sport brand bike.

"Pollin, keep the change. I will be back soon." he added to the shopkeeper.

"Should I drive?" he asked me in a bad mood.

"No, sit," I said to make him smile.

Entry to the Museum...

"10% discount sale! Sir come in; madam come in! 10% discount!" a teenager of 12 stood at its brick red large compound.

"Kid, is she inside?" I asked him politely in the ear deafening horns on the busy street.

"Uh?" he asked curiously, fisting his black eagle brows.

"Your mom"

"O yes, she is there".

He pointed at the peaceful door inside the compound. As we walked past the brick compound, the heavy sounds of the traffic were muffled greatly. We now only heard the rustling sounds of the teak leaves. She had planted 24 of them some years ago here. It is great to see them caring for you as you enter as a guest.

"Jerry, you know this place?"

"It is my 252nd visit."

"Then, I can say that you are more reliable than any local rat."

The gallery is itself a treat to watch. It is made completely of dark grey wood. It has 2 floors, colored glass windows in the front and the most unique antiques in the city.

"Why is this door creaking so much?" Markov complained quickly after entering.

"What is this? Where is the gallery?"

"Markov, this is the gallery."

"But it has stairs, that too leading down. And it is dark. I can't see through 5 stairs down."

"Markov, the stairs are downward but the ground is elevated. You will understand as you walk in."

As he stepped through few stairs he exclaimed,

"Oh, I get it. It feels like stepping down but it returns to the same level. The whole staircase is tilted upward from the door."

And We're in.

Mary welcomed us. She left the watch she was repairing and smiled.

She described *every piece*.

I carelessly looked at them, the 252nd time. It would be a Guinness record, if I reveal it.

"Well, how about that?"

"It is well made! And is made of fine metal casing. The diamonds are not real though."

"Oh. Well, this?"

"It costs 2000 dollars."

"Jerry, can I buy it?"

"Please consider my limitations, Markov"

"Fine. This one."

"Oh, this is only for decoration."

I thought, "why is saying so? I never heard her on dummies in her gallery"

But he asked a few more times, holding her hands, grumping his face, rolling a couple of tears from his sharp curvy eyelashes. She refused.

“I will pay you as much as you wish!” he said.

She took a pause- zipped it into her vanity bag.

“Please don’t ask” she dusted her final words over the icing.

Markov turned his face away from the blossoms. He walked upstairs, avoiding looks over the shelves.

I shouldn't let him go without me.

But he was out- within seconds- miles afar from the gallery- on his blue Yamaha.

The setting sun streamed from the heavens through the door. It made its way over the stairs and narrowed down to darkness now, as her key locked the wooden closing of the shop.

I came out and continued on.

Someone gently embraced my shoulder.

And I turned back in silence.

An aged gentleman with a beard and a white fancy turban. His eyes were scarcely visible amidst his vermillion covered forehead. He stood with a smile and prayed as I turned towards him.

He stepped right in front of me, pulling out his mystical calendars and photographs framed in ply. His hands pushed them out from his warm bag. It was a business.

“I won't buy it. Leave me” I said.

He laughed,

“Son.
Remember, I sense the bloody hell of crime you committed 2 years ago!”
He smeared my forehead with ashes even after my refusal and holding seashells in hand, he said
"Good luck, may Cops don't find you"
"What?" I replied.

He asked for a few coins, like those old telephone booths, to answer further.

"Good luck, go away!" I screamed and he went without a word.

Now, I need to go home. Markov left me hurrying himself in emotion.

It's already a cream moon and I can't go, walking miles.

I sat on the gallery's compound looking straight at the deserted roads. And the truth is,

'Empty mind is a devil's workshop'

The only light leaning my arms was name board of the gallery.

I left my sharp boots and walked around quietly to kill time.

I came across a carving of an umbrella on the wall. I softened my head over it. And pushed it gently.

It is just a closed window. Mary had painted a thick brown glaze over the edges of it, a few months ago, to avoid the entry of intense rays of midday sun.

This is enough for a thin lad like me to enter inside the gallery and enjoy for a while. The window is 10 and half feet above the gallery floor. If I jump down, one is- me dying. Two is- the loud sound waking the people of the area, for my funeral.

There is a cupboard to the right of the window. I placed my legs slowly over it and slid over it.

The clocks on the wall showed 40 minutes for my stunt. I strongly feel that I made it in 5 minutes, the *Jackie Chan* way. The clocks are mostly done. I will break their beaks soon.

I glided down the cupboard slowly, slowly.

I stayed inside looking at every historic piece in finest detail. After walking for hours inside, I decided to check the cash counter. In the counter, I saw her handbag sitting still. I remembered her hiding the key bunch. And it is inside the bag.

I gently pushed it into the pocket to have fun. The faulty main door locks only from outside. So, I safely walked out of the shop!

The next day, I rode on my bike to entertain my ears. I was extremely happy to see Mary and Markov having a serious quarrel. She asks who stole it. And he says he didn't!

And it went loud. The aged beard fellow stood to console them. I walked with a great innocence and stood beside enjoying the quarrel.

I managed with my stunning words. And when everything went smooth, the beard fellow said,

"What were you doing inside the gallery yesterday night?"

Mary caught the words so cleverly and stood staring at me folding her hands tight.

He added more words, turning the case at me. How much rage will he take for not dropping coins for him?

Mary's eyes clouded. She cried.

Her knees fell to the floor and she told us,

"It was the key bunch of my martyred husband. It was the only belonging I was left with."

My plan looked merely a childish reply. It is still a question of esteem to give it back from the pocket. The situation demanded and I took my hand into the pocket. Before my hands reached, we heard a sturdy motorcar sounding by the door of the gallery. The aroma of lavenders; And an army boot's touch on the stairs.

The lavender in his hand fell down.

"They said you were no more!?," she said.

"It was just to trick the enemies," he said.

I dropped the key bunch by the flower pot and quickly came out.

December 18 |

I lived with her. I can't distinguish her name but I still do remember her face and her startling smile she gave for my words.

I feel lost in thoughts. I see myself turning free in a pool of dark memories. I now see a teddy bear with worn out wool skin and a hole in its button eye. I see myself plucking it demonstrating the meaning of "revenge" to my sister, it was in my teens. And there's my mum, she is sleeping on the floor!

"Oh heaven, why has she turned so careless? I would have never minded buying her a soft cushion" I think.

And then she calls me, with a whisper, a shout and a scream. I was on the bed the next moment!?

I stayed on the pillows, my hands over her lap. Why is she crying? I was fine. In my next gasp for breath, my cousin appeared before me. But... but, he held my wife closely. My wife was happy holding his hands, wasn't she?

She says to me that she's married to him!

In the next breath, I was still on pillows. An action movie scene playing back and forth on the television kept beside me; the scene of a slow walk into a dark room. And 'Harry, wake up!', moans my mother from the right side. Why's she calling my previous name? And why is my cousin holding my wife? I am transfixed. 'Come on, let's play, Harry Elijah!' a voice screams from the other end.

My mind is sounding quite larger than it should. And things seem like the cut-paste, every tick.

But then I experienced a sudden pain in my chest and felt the return of my breathing. I woke up from my bed. My eyes were now focused on the green cup of French wine beside my bed stool. The wine is over. The settling cup trembled my side stool for a few seconds.

My eyes reflected some lilies and roses hanging above my bed, on the French ceiling, for a minute.

I slid my hand on the bed sheet, searching for my lost heavy eyeglasses, which came into my life in the 1920s. The cotton lint and hairy fibres of the rug scratched my lower palm and gave out a sense of soft sound of brushes. I tried lifting my spine from bed and kept my sore feet over the flower pattern matted floor.

I just walked from there down the stairs. Dust spores were sprouting from every corner!

Why's everything gone old? I ask myself. Maybe my mum has answers. Mom! I am up!

Her response may take some time, ok maybe even longer?

Fine, one minute further, for it's a surprise to her that I am no more ill and in bed, did she hear?

Wait, he... he heard it. But, hanging on the wall. He, my father stood quiet as a gentleman on the wall. Where was I all these years?

As I walked down in thoughts, I felt some stubborn stuff near the sofa mat. Why is she sleeping on the floor? I would never have minded buying her a soft cushion. She was by my legs sleeping. But is she alive?

I hear a scream from outside the window "See there! There's he! Playing a gamble with us. That day Mr. Caleb, today she. We have got them red handed!"

A couple of locks undesirably locked my free hands. I don't understand. The court too had no pity on me. To the jails from my sleep. Weird.

Say anything but the world has changed a lot ever since that day. All I remember is slapping my wife all of a sudden when she told me something really horrible. It was me slapping her, but I myself felt the slap. A brief shut down at my nerves and I fell off to the ground.

She's saying to the people around that I choked her. Lady, don't lie, I say.

'She never lies', my mum said as she came there. And my closed eyes opened on that day when I was arrested by policemen. The silence in the solitary prison is now where I stay. Though I am locked in bars of jail, I never get to see the rails around me, not even a single day. Bcz, I haven't even seen a dim light in the whole place. The food slid from somewhere dark once a day. Even if I see a spark of light, my mind shall release loads of dopamine. I shaved all my nails on the wall trying to see a spark of light. It was a very dull day for me, when I finally got to walk out of the cell. I heard of a voice that called me for a minute outside. Few fingers guided me somewhere away from my cell. With the locks in hand, I was pushed into a pit in a rush. A man whipped me with loads of wires and then the voice yelled, 'forget everything, if any' and then other voice repeated,

'Forget everything, if any!!'.

The voice guided guards to send me back to the cell and to bring the next prisoner. The guards whispered all along the way to the cell. They said it quite often, 'These men….' followed by a breath of distress.

I was thrown back into the cellar again and the rude men went out or should I say the foot stabs stopped.

Months, years I don't know: An eternity later, I got to see a flame of light. It was when a person lit his cigar just outside the cellar. The little light shone on me like the sun.

My eyes felt damaged. He called me, 'There can be nothing left for you, young man. Try coming out of this cell.'

The words had a deep bass tone to it. As I moved towards his voice, I realised there were no railings around my cell. An arm touched my shoulder saying, 'Even I am a prisoner of this jail. Let's go, come.'

I followed him. He got me out. Was there nobody to stop us from escaping?

I felt separated from blindness and discovered the existence of my flesh and body as I went with him through the corridor. My shadows gradually appeared in front of me in moon lit starry night.

He said pointing at the shadow, 'This was you all these days, but now your shadow has agreed to live outside you.'

I never dared to know who he was. My thoughts had lost its tendency to question and expect.

We sailed on a boat with twenty more people for a few minutes. I saw myself in the reflection. Heavens! Is it me?

'Why were you in jail?' he asked me.

'For no reason', I said and asked him the same question.

'Who arrested you?!'

'Maybe it was the Police arresting me?

Things were drowsy that day' - me.

'Just have a breath for a while. Go sit near the pole for a while, it will blow more air over you than it blows here. I will join your conversation after my sherry.'

I sat as he said. The water waves around just rose up and settled down with bloping water sounds. The boat sailed quietly and leaned towards the wind. I could hear it. The air gave instructions to the boat to move forward. It was just more than a swoosh and a calm breeze repeating in intervals.

Hey there. I am his daughter. Just thought to add a few lines to my father's journal. He was just drunk.

Chef's Delicacy I

"Wake up Garry!!"

Our delightful chef Garry, wakes up from the bed. He looks at the alarm clock and puts it into water.

Immediately walks to the bathroom, and locks the door tightly.

His first task is to have a 'Beauty Bath'

It is something more than a beauty bath actually... It is an extra leisure time for him to get some more sleep in the tub.

Then he takes a regular shower with soap, covers his body with a new set of uniform and walks into the room to sleep on bed again.

His room looks as good as garbage. He sprays the room with jasmine flavored room freshener twice.

His mother shouts "Garry!! You are a 5-star hotel chef. Don't you feel ashamed?? It's already 8!"

Saying so, she opens Garry's room door. As she opens the door, she sneezes loudly. It was Garry's special room freshener...

He steps down with half closed eyes. He sits over the dining table and reluctantly opens the coverings on food. After having breakfast, he lifts up his cup of water. But this was the first time he felt the cup so heavy... Opening his eyes, he saw the cat's tail in his hand.

The cat escaped quickly and made a moan.

He leaves the home...

In minutes, he reached the "Royale Delicacy 5-star restaurant" which is within a mile far from his home. He's the Head Chef there...

As he came near the entrance, a watchman saluted him. Flattered by the salute, Garry said, "Aye gentleman!!" and grabbed the watchman's tie.

But not even a moment passed, the watchman fell like a light-weighted cupboard... Because, the safety pin in chef's cuff had dragged his shirt so nicely. Saying sorry to him, he walked in.

A customer called, "Can I know what is fresh here??"

"It's me," replied the chef with a dignified smiley face. "I just took a bath!!"

"I asked about food!!!" exclaimed the customer.

"Oh!! Just a minute, our waiter will fulfil your needs".

He approached the door of the hotel kitchen to call the waiter. He pushed the glass door. Door didn't open. He pushed it with all the effort. No, not even now. He pushed it like Superman pushing the tilted building. Just then, a heavy sound came... He farted.

Seeing his heavy work from inside the kitchen, the sous chef came and opened the glass door. He said,

"You just have to pull it!"

As he entered the kitchen, everyone greeted him. He asked, "So, what's our first dish to prepare today? Come on!!" The waiter went to tell the long list of orders. But then the sous chef cut him short and said, "Uh it's… Popcorn, Chef!!"

Garry exclaimed, "Oh!! Popcorn is an easy one.

Hurry! Go on with your work. I will prepare it!!" He kept a saucepan on the stove and lit the fire. He added olive oil... then took an empty basket and called the sous chef,

"Keep an eye on this vessel!! I will be back soon."

"Where are you going??"

"To pluck corns from the field!"

"Chef… corns are already here..."

"Oh!! I see!!! Well, I knew it actually huh haa…"

For sous chef this didn't seem funny…

Garry then added the corns to the vessel and turned his face up. He gave a sharp look at everyone, as if he was a legend. He then closed the vessel with a thin plate and smiled.

"That won't work, chef!!"

"Sshh!! I am perfect. Keep quiet!"

He stood observing with his face held just above the vessel. Just then, plate closed over the hot vessel jumped right up to his face and gave a nice kick. Everyone burst into laughter. Who knows, maybe even the doors laughed too!!

With his red face, he came out from the kitchen. By then, a customer sitting near the kitchen asked the chef, "I saw that thing happening to you. Was it very painful??" Hearing these words, Garry tried showing off. He acted as if he was very fine. To show that he was alright, he took a glass of water from the table and filled his mouth with water.

Customer spoke casually, "Today the weather is so calm!".

Garry reacted, "Yes..."

But, with the letters y-e-s, water in his mouth smoothly piped out over the customer's face... Chef himself laughed loudly, shaking his body up and down seeing that guy's watery face. By then, a loud sound peaked out. Yes, he farted again.

It was already too much. Customer stood up and smiled at Garry. And smilingly he gave him a slap. "Your face is looking like a sweating crocodile!!!" and again laughed, Our Garry Legend.

"Yea absolutely and here is another crocodile!" said the customer.
Garry turned and asked, "Where??
Where??"

Just then the customer lifted up his leg and kicked Garry.

Though Garry felt it as fun for some time, he felt embarrassed. He didn't come to the hotel for days. When he did come to the hotel after days, he saw that customer again. He went and said, "U shouldn't have Kicked me, after giving a Slap…

Because, Kick comes before a Slap, even in the

Dictionary…"

The customer smiled, and said, "You are not as bad as you seem! I am sorry for behaving so rude that day."

"I am sorry too!!

By the way sir, order your food! I will myself cook everything for you this time!".

"I would like to order... chicken fries, paneer pasta, fried-rice and popcorn"

"Uh what did you say at last, sir??"

"I said POPCORN!!"

"Oh, Ok sir, I will have it ready"

Garry was serious. He went inside... He looked passionate than ever before. Everyone in the kitchen stepped back. He prepared chicken fries, paneer pasta and fried-rice. The Sous Chef was astonished when he tasted them. They tasted really delicious. "It's ...like heaven on a plate" complimented the customer.

"Oh thanks, I will be back soon sir, with your popcorn," replied Garry from the kitchen...

Everyone in the kitchen happily stood away seeing such a great chef...

Chef Garry stood with pride and kept the vessel on the stove. With a heavy smile, he lit up the stove... Poured the olive oil. Added the corn. Closed the vessel with a plate and turned towards the kitchen staff and said, "It will be ready soon!" They smiled happily.

As the chef turned back his head in pride and looked, the plate popped up again and hit his face. Oh, poor Garry, he is back with his red face again.

Ben's Grim World |

Witty and Charming, I introduce you to Ben Jims. Ben Jims is a young boy who still goes to primary school. He is 9-year-old. He lives with his family happily. He is ever-smiling and naughty. Now let's go with the story!!

It's a Sunday and Ben wakes up, hugs his teddy, and gently wakes up from his bed. He runs out to the garden and gives a cozy hug to all the trees out there. He then rolls himself on moist grass and

runs again. Now, unable to tolerate the itching, goes straight to the bathroom. After a great shower, he goes for his breakfast. The Day goes with joy for him. In the evening, he goes to a

supermarket to buy his favorite choco-flakes. The choco-flake has a cute dinosaur puppet as a free gift. This is the sole reason why he buys it.

Everything went so well with him the whole day. He got a nice dino and even got his favorite noodles for supper. After a few hours, His mother said, "It's already night, cutey. Time to go to bed !!". He went and wore his brand-new nightclothes. He even wore his cozy sleep cap. He looked so cute.

He looked at the sky from his window and wished a happy night

for the whole universe.

He gently went to sleep, but the smile on his face did not fade away. He didn't even have a tooth. Imagine how cute he looked as he opened his mouth?! awww...

The Next Day, as little Ben opened his eyes, he saw something scary. He saw things which he never was able to see before. He was not alone in his room... Some spirits were moving inside his room. One of them moved through his hand effortlessly.

As Ben turned his attention towards his bed, the bed turned invisible. He was floating above. He rubbed his eyes and gave out a loud shout. His parents rushed towards the room in anxiety.

But, before his parents came into the room, everything turned back to normal. As he shouted, everything disappeared.

But still, he was shivering in fear and was in hurry to express what he saw. Parents hugged him and said "No fear dear brave boy!"

Ben was about to tell his experience, but hearing the words 'brave boy' made him feel, "No I can't tell my parents such a weird experience. They will call me a coward if I say so!!". He convinced his parents that it was all because of a bad dream.

The next time, when he experienced it, something got added. He was able to move in the air, floating.

As he moved, he saw the Truth…

The incidents which had happened in the room long before appeared in front of his eyes. People who lived there in the past were speaking, shouting and walking in front of him. He even sensed their thoughts and emotions. When he tried touching their bodies, he felt suffocated to breathe.

He tapped his legs over the spirits around him. Quickly, he was pulled into layers of rubbery sheath. He saw his life as he went through it. He witnessed almost every moment of his life happening.

Yes!! He saw the PAST!!

He travelled speedily and arrived into a misty foggy room. He walked over the floor of the room… His steps printed blue marks as he walked. Sandy dust fell over him whenever he turned his head…

He relaxed... Slowly the place around him turned back into his room...

He went and saw himself in the mirror with curiosity. He was Ben… 9-year-old kid… He stood staring at the mirror for a while. Looking at his cute little face in the mirror, he smiled... He smeared his face with talcum powder and got lost in beautifying himself. No matter how dreadful the situation may be, if he sees himself in the mirror, he gets lost in happiness. This is how he was in his childhood.

In the meanwhile, his family got shifted to Alaska, USA. His childhood continued there. The shift changed his mood. He made new friends. He totally forgot about the weird experiences. He went to school and engaged himself in study and play just like a normal kid.

He was a naughty boy though… He used to take the chalks before the teacher entered the classroom and threw them at the teacher.

He once had kept a water filled packet on the class bench and had made his friend wet his pants. And when the boy's parents came to complain, Ben sent them back with wet pants, too. Ben was lost in his naughtiness.

Summer Vacation returned! He now was as excited as the audience in the circus. He planned to visit his aunt's home in

London. He asked his parents. They refused at first. But unable to see the boy's sorrow, decided to take him to London.

New Place Brought him happiness

He flew to London with his parents and reached his favorite place 'Aunt's Home'. His Parents, due to workload, left him in London and came back to Alaska.

Here in London, he happily spent his days. His Aunt treated him with hot chocolates, dino-flakes, hot cheesy pizza and many more. Enjoying this feast, Ben now had turned into a small elephant. All he was missing was a trunk.

He went and pleaded with his aunt. "Aunt!! I want to become slim. Girls will not like me, if I don't"

"Oh gosh!! Don't blame me. I didn't tell you to eat so much" said the Aunt Elephant. Fed up with his look, he himself started to exercise every morning. He woke up at 6 AM and did pushups, meditation and jogging.

When he sat for meditation, he started to see the spirits again. He opened his eyes in fright.

"I thought that my weird experience in childhood was just a dream. But...It seems to be real…".

He went and dialed his mum with a telephone kept on the tea table. He said that he is in an emergency. His parents took him back to Alaska. He explained everything.

He was taken to a hospital. Doctors did not know the real thing happening. But they confirmed that there's no danger, as it was not showing any difference in his brain. They said that he is 'daydreaming'. They concluded this even in their medical report and also gave medicines for it.

Medicines did nothing. Ben understood that it was not his weakness, instead was his ability.

Ben now wanted to know more about the spirits around him! So, he decided to talk with the spirits. For that he chose an empty bungalow in the vicinity. People had complained of spirit voices being heard from the place. So, he considered it as the right place.

The bungalow in the name of a person called
'Raven Kad'. But Raven lived in Canada and so this bungalow was left closed.

Ben jumped over the compound and entered the bungalow through a small opening in the store room. He then roamed

throughout the bungalow. He found a peaceful place. It was dark and dusty. A big glass window opened the room to the outer world. Sunlight entered through it and the view was stunning.

He saw many belongings in the room. He touched them with his skinny hands. There was a gramophone. He kept his hand on it and turned it on. Hissing murmurs came from it. Then he sat on an old-fashioned rocking chair. A walker passing near that bungalow saw that chair rocking and heard the hissing sound.

That man really took his heart to mouth and ran like an Olympics runner, misunderstanding that as a ghost play.

Ben was not aware of anything happening outside and hence continued. He closed his eyes and sharply held his hands over his head. Everything went the same way. He started seeing the past incidents that happened in that room. And then a spirit came to him. It called his name.

Ben built up his courage and touched it. The spirit went inside him! And Ben was thrown out of his body... The dark spirit occupied Ben's body. And Ben stayed floating outside his body. Now, Ben spoke up, not actually Ben, the dark spirit inside Ben's body.

"I had died 12 years ago, but I had to stay here as a ghost. How horrible was it indeed!?!! I had never thought that I could make

this! Today because of you, I will be free. I will burn your body and I will get myself to heaven" and saying this,

New Ben Jims walked out from the bungalow with a weird smile of satisfaction on the face. New Ben Jims hanged himself to bungalow's compound and burnt the body in wood fires.
While Ben stayed inside the Bungalow forever as a ghost, without his body…...

The Golden Brick |

A humble family. A man, his wife and 2 children living together in an average city kitchen sized wooden house. The Man has a rough sounding name Cadmus Sword, but he is as soft-hearted as a cow.

He had married 'Elisa', who even is a humble faced woman. This pair has 2 pale dull kids 'Jack' and 'Oliver'. These kids have never seen the inside of a school.

Both Cadmus and Elisa are day laborers. The kids work at a flower shop as helpers. Cadmus does night shift work once a week. Kids work at a flower shop all day and come home by 4 PM and sit in the house staring at each other. The flower shop owner gives them only 2 loaves of bread to eat in the afternoon. Nothing goes into their stomachs from then. Elisa returns from

her work at 6:50 PM, and she too sits staring at the faces of her kids. They sit staring at each other; they don't even talk a word. Because their empty stomachs don't let them talk. When Cadmus returns at 9 PM, Elisa goes to cook some rice gruel. Cadmus and Elisa eat 2 bowls of gruel, while kids are given a single bowl of gruel to share with each other. They are all tired and sleepy. But who gets a deep sleep when their stomach is dry??? They all sleep with half-open eyes. When the sun-shine lights their faces in the morning, they wake up from their resting position. Elisa again cooks some gruel. Kids are given one and half a spoon of gruel to eat. Elisa and Cadmus share a bowl. Kids haven't heard their father's voice since the past 3 months as the work and fatigue was so high.

There is only one festive season in which these humble faces are smiley. It's the election season. It comes once every 5 years. The candidates give money and bread loaves to all the houses in the neighborhood for voting their name in the election.

Elisa usually goes to work as a construction worker. She is often called to work at house constructions. Her Job is to take the bricks on her head and reach them out to needed places in the construction area. She gets 40 cents for her one-day work.

On other hand, Cadmus works at a cloth manufacturing factory. He is the one who carries the heavy baskets of finished clothes. He puts them over his head and walks towards the big trucks standing outside the factory. He keeps them in the back of the trucks and turns his body again to bring one more cloth basket.

All he is paid is $2 cents for every basket of clothes.
He manages to carry 68 of such baskets and earns 1.36 dollars each day. But almost $1.23 goes into buying the rice for the day's meal.

Somehow, Cadmus manages to save some money. But his son Oliver goes ill very often and the medicines take in all the savings.

The poor family left the town and went to Belltown. Cadmus managed to get a job there. Elisa continued as a construction worker in that place. The kids now are left alone at home.

Cadmus slowly got promotions at work and managed to earn 5 dollars a day. Elisa earned 45 cents a day. Overtime, Cadmus left working night shifts and came home earlier than before. Now their meal was no more rice gruel. They ate pancakes!!

Now, as all of them got enough meals, their voices slowly started to come out.

Oliver after many years spoke up, "Mum!! Meal was tasty…"

After the meal, Cadmus came near the kids, ruffled their hair and with a happy smile said, "Surprise!!!" Cadmus gave them a box wrapped in a purple cover. As kids opened the box, it was something beyond their expectation.

The box contained 6 delicious chocolate cookies and 3 cake slices.

For the first time ever in life, kids tasted some cookies and sweet cakes. The kids enjoyed the snacks very much.

After few days, when Jack's 9th birthday arrived,

Cadmus gifted him a nice bicycle as a present. Both Jack and Oliver showered their joys out, by riding the cycle again and again. Elisa was so happy now.

She went to Cadmus and said, "I love U!! I knew, one or the other day, this would happen" and hugged him very tightly.

December came and bells jiggled.

New decors and smiley faces had made the house look very lively and new. They brought the new Christmas tree and kept it inside their house.

Every One of them got a hat on their heads, and received a gift. Oliver got a nice watch; Jack got his favorite teddy and Elisa got a new cozy colorful sweater.

Elisa questioned, "Cadmus? What did you get for

Christmas?"

"My happy Family"

Elisa smiled. Everyone enjoyed their special meal and went to sleep with satisfied minds.

Elisa had a wish to gift something to Cadmus for Christmas. She woke up early in the morning the next day and made a beautiful pot with colorful design on it. She placed many bunches of fresh flowers in it. She kept it beside Cadmus, when he was still in sound sleep.

It's hard to explain his joy when he saw that surprise.

Like so, their life took a nice leap from utter poverty to hunger less happy life. But this didn't mean that their struggle was over.

An unexpected flood broke out and grabbed their lovely home and all their belongings.

There was no one for the family to share the sorrow. On seeing the humble home shattered into pieces and floating over the standing water, Elisa went unstoppable. She cried so much. It looked as if all the clouds in the sky came into her eyes and rivered the water through her cheeks. Their Dreams went with water hopelessly.

Elisa and Cadmus built a new hut out of clay and dry grass. Once again, they lived out of rice gruel. All started again.

Elisa once again started going to construction works.

As usual, she woke up early and went to the workplace today.

The house had to be demolished and the leftover bricks were to be brought down to load them in the trucks.

She started her old boring work, carrying the bricks.

The work went for the whole day, and when there were only countable numbers of bricks left, she was the only worker.

Her weak eyes went towards the bricks. She grabbed 1…2…3…4 then stopped. There was a brick dimly shining. She threw the bricks in hand and picked that one up. She cleaned the brick using

some water and soap. It was golden yellow in color. She looked here and there. There was no one. She secretly kept it inside her food bag. It was 7 PM when she successfully escaped from the place. She came home.

"Cadmus!! See, what I have got. Our life will turn bright again!!!"

Cadmus and the kids were extremely hungry. They have been starving for the past 2 days. They just smiled.

Cadmus spoke,

"Elisa please feed us some gruel. Please!!"

Elisa was in excitement and she forgot that they were on bare stomach for 2 days.

She said, "Sure!! Sure Cadmus!! Why not… But, just wait for 10 minutes, I will just go to a Gold Shop and come back with an enormous amount of money. Then we'll have a rich meal, why only gruel??!!!"

She heard not even a word and went like a rabbit. The Gold Merchant was quite busy. After 20 minutes of great chat on his phone, he came near the woman.

Elisa was floating in the sky. She gave the brick and asked the merchant to give her money.

The Merchant looked at it. And said, "Surely, I would have given U….

If this brick was real gold….

Ok, I was just joking. I can give U $5,000"

Woman smiled and her face turned bright. "Yes!! Yes!! Give me the money."

She took the cash and walked happily. She came home. Opened the closed door.

Cadmus and the kids were lying on the ground.

"Oh!! Look at them, they are sleeping. Maybe they were extremely hungry, I will cook them food quickly!"

She went near Cadmus and whispered, "My lovely dear husband, see what ur wife has brought!! This will take away all our sufferings. U asked for rice gruel, right?? See I will now cook you some golden rice!!!!"

"Cadmus?? Cad…mus??? I know U are tired, but just speak up a word…please??!"

"My cute little sons!! At least you both?? Come on dear, say a word. Ok… just give me a smile!!!"

One time…2 times, then 3 and then again…. they didn't wake up. All 3 of them had slipped into deep sleep, from starvation. So deep sleep that they were not going to wake up again...

Boba and His Tea

A Day in the Life of an Egg |

There was a very unique person, whom u never heard of...

He has done almost all the weird stuff; anyone can ever do... He is such a good entertainer ... His way of routine never failed to entertain readers like us...

I am speaking about Merro!!

He is a Little Teen Boy who does weird things... Merro is not a human, he is a Dumb Little Cute Egg!!!
Sometimes, he wears small pants and little socks. He loves giving everyone a Spooky Look. He has his own Dummy House, in which he enjoys his eggy life.

In the House, He has a sponge bed for him. but this little dumbo goes and sleeps inside a tiny dog shed. He hates talking to people!! But, always loves smiling. His weird smile starts as a cute curve on his mouth and then opens like a palace door (with 2 teeth knocked off)!! He once met his neighbor and something special happened...

"Hello Merro egg!! Happy Evening, how are u??"

"I am gooood"

"How is your life going??"

"Goood"

"Why are u smiling so much?? "

"I still haven't brushed my teeth. hee-hee"

Weirdness goes on!! He goes outside his house and stands on the road. There, he stares weirdly at the old aunties and uncles passing by!! The City Corporation has even placed a Caution Board "Staring Egg Ahead" and the board also has these words written in bold
"Aunties & Uncles!! Careful".

By the time the Sun sets and the moon shoots up to its place, this dummy egg goes into his kitchen and plays music. He never sings but, never stops acting as if he sings.

He then goes to sleep !! then again opens his eyes the very mid-night and starts eating the Corn-Oats flake bowl !! just as time turns to 4 AM he switches on the TV and watches "The Super Hen show"!! But He doesn't listen to sounds from T.V, He wants his neighbors to have these SOUNDS into their ears. So, he throws the speakers into their house and switches them on!!

Haven't the neighbors thrown it back??
They do it every time ... But as soon they throw it back... It comes back like a bowling ball from the Dummy House... It has become a very well-known sound for the people of his neighborhood... They have now come to a conclusion... They get up from their beds and hit their heads with their hands until Morning wakes!!

Nature I

How beautiful…How auspicious...
Remember the inspiring and refreshing tales of the hanging garden that revolves the sun?

Those tall old well-built trees with fresh air surrounding just like bees round the Honeycomb.
Those green grassy patches on the body of those rocks…some rough and some tough.
Ground gripping the auspicious calm trees is moist... with dried and fallen green leaves blanketing the soil like a bedsheet. With wings they fly, great birds in their own home sky landing for a snack with happy murmurs and soothing choirs. By the time sunshine enters the deeply wild, there is a marathon of shifting colors and shades with little dust and droplets masking the shine, glittering the hive, covering the cave of trees with fog lit in fairy.

On a clear sky, resting squirrels spot a disturbance in the sky's ever-changing screen of wonder. The sky rolls out a blanket, pink clouds puff in swift, white ones swirl, grey ones rest. They hug,

they sprint, they dash and they break. The snowman checks his carrot and peeks at the peak. He has a rigid smile on his face.

How come everything is set for happiness??
Nature entertained itself with its turbulent breeze.
But the breeze did not stop.
Ice Mountains shed their tears, turning snow into Water.
Trees dry up as if they were depressed.
When Oceans invade the lands, LIFE shatters and the land flattens. Nothing more left for happiness.

The sky is now a horror movie!! Sky now shows up its lightning teeth and heart-breaking Roars. Acids spray from clouds in place of water drops. Forests no longer tolerate the down press!! Their Anger turns to Fire, burning everything within and surrounding the forest. The soil now turns Black, as there is only Ash to blanket its surface. Meteorites hit, shining the Night Sky!! Asteroids Bump, Making Day-light and large destruction. No one left on lands, but the fishes and sea horses swim their way... But there remains no mercy....

Grace I

They are going back leaving me a heavy bag on my shoulders.
My elder sister was still in their arms of grace, but not me.
Why?
I am still 5.

They call me horrid.
They call me a cry toy.
A young lady welcomes me inside the cage, opening the gate,
pulling my arm as I step in.

I sit, I stand, I sprint, I toil.
I rip my dried lips,
And speak, “I want my toffee".
She shows me the moon, for it's only a picture,
and draws me into a big room.

There're plenty of others and they are strangers. Yet I share many things in common.
I lack two front teeth and they do too.

I want many toffees and they do too.
They shout, I do too.
If they cling their eyebrows up and down, I do too.
I spend my day skipping my sorrow.
But on the evening, I wait for them sincerely to pick me up,
I see them coming !
They sprinted towards, holding an umbrella showering their arms in the strong swift rain.
They are mine, my lovely ones who defeat the angels hiding in the tempered sky above, I say.
And I hug them at the gates, tight in peace.
And then the other kids too swift up, crowding to hug them close.
My tender fingers lost their part and came out from the branch of soft touch.
When they closed the gates of the mesh, I saw their faces and they were not my parents.
"I am left for this new
home." I whispered, saddened.
She, with her sounding anklets, came to me.
Graced my forehead and assured my heart.
Her eyes calmed the waves of my heart's tempest for one more wait.

And I rested my ocean for one more night.

Ruins I

The flower lies over, a little slant, to pop some buckets of fresh pollen into the breeze of southern deccan.

The soft petals of white stretch their palms and wait for a bee to bee around. Who knew? it would be cut, not owing to pruning but way before. In the late midnight, when an innocent mind pricked its neck, to serve his god residing inside a temple. The pillars clearly were once stones and rocks washed by the waves at the beaches of Amaravati. Now were sharp pillars leafed in unique art of the lost glory to serve an untold purpose.

A group of carved out dwarf men moved up the pillars in square loops and round swirls like the tendrils of a creeper, shining the depths and peaks on the sandstone.

The peace hall stood inside the cave with the guarding pillars of its own. The floor had a little flat disc. Lines leafed over it were curvy, dark and fell into a spiral. From afar, the disc resembled a shining seashell printed onto the floor. The walls had many paintings. painted in striking boxy art, stamping the age. The king, the queen, the popular men of the time, achievements in

the rule and the jokers and traitors of the kingdom's playing card pack looked bright in the paintings. Every tap on the central disc of the floor made a sound, different every time. Overall, it stood as a tower of the late emperor's wealth.

Now, the pale teen who knows not a saw dust, walks with his sooted poor lantern lit up to its most, there's no oil left, it just swings around, much deeper and darker than a lady's young eyes. The teen enters, printing his wet little foot on the sandstone stairs. He drops the flower on the statue and falls down to its feet, in humble stature. The travelled legs sharpen pain, silver anklets press the nerves and his sorrow comes out with the pain and he says,

"I met a trader. Sold my good sheep. Asked my coins. It was a tough time, so he promised to return it late. But gave me back pain and none other more or less. The village goddess and he have sent me out from a cheat, and here I am, running days, breaking nerves, walking a million miles."

And prayed a never-ending list whose end seemed to arrive by the time of his death.

Holding the sooted lamp he said, sitting under the dusky blue shade of the night, just by the eagle tower,

"I will serve here for you"

Giving a new hope of revival for the abandoned lost glory of the town, he slept hardly on the thin bamboo mat, covering half of it over him for cold.

The statue is still awake. His lamps are still on. The five petalled flower is sitting on the foot of the elegant statue, dead and dry. In peace, the dead dream leans on the foot more, to rest and shine for a day more as a decor at the finest foot.

Every lamp drains out by late night. There is only a star in the sky, still visible. And near his toes, only a pot, still eyes on. The anxious pot sat alive in devotion, even after its oils went away, waiting to reach his feet.

It shone in brilliance, and took the leap as a long fire thread. The fierce lights of the lamp shone sharply swiveling itself with the wind, also reddening the sides of the white flower by the feet. The very moment, the life of the last lamp jumped into Ash well. But the red sides on the flower widened, reaching its bowl. The entire flower took the heat and burnt in a glow.

On one hand, the lamp pot drained, flowed and reached the feet as yellow red light.

And on the other, the dead flower took its cremation at the feet of the divine.

The flower was a piece of ash when the teen woke in the morning and served as his bhasma by the evening.

Damp I

The road on the closed harbor is marvelous. But old.
It still has those white bars, but old.
It takes you nowhere but to the seas. It ends in a cliff owing to seas below.

Chains are too weak to hold the boats still.
The old oil drums spill out dripping drop by drop.
The husky oil shines out the rainbows on the wet black road. The waves are unable to wave over it, for it is on the cliff. The road waits to cherish new stamps on its back. But knees down with a couple of cracks after a year-long wait.
The road is no more in hope to expect a visitor and steeps down the edges bowing to the seas.
Just then, an infant bird learning to fly lost its grip to grace the grounds. And its little jump on the road made the day.

The bird flew up and high, never looking down again.
The road now broke falling to the seas, never looking up again.

Bill wants money

"Your reading bill came out to be 420 dollars and 42 cents.

*Story tax included"

Pls pay it to this person.

"One drop from the ocean doesn't empty it."- says Bill

Thanks Giving ++

This time no fun.
"Your bill came out to be 420 dollars 42 cents,
sir."
This time you may strictly refuse to pay the bill and might even throw the book at the waiter of our restaurant, yelling loudly in front of everyone.
And we, the good souls, will give you a meditation school pamphlet to join. For we get a commission from it.
And DON'T forget to send selfies with our book to your friends, so that they too can throw it and join the meditation school. (Holy moly, another commission!!)

If you wish to give a feedback/opinion, send them directly to my mail- shortcomix.strip@gmail.com

Before you stop reading.

Do you see a dog flying above your head??

If yes – Goodnight

If no – drink wine.

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Short stories and Illustrations by Shreyas Hegde

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